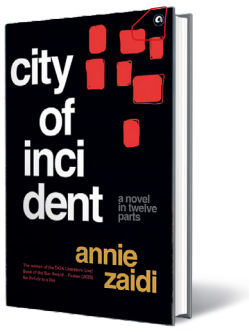
The Lives of Others

Annie Zaidi's lyricism is sometimes at odds with the harsh urban realities she hopes to portray



CITY OF INCIDENT: A NOVEL IN TWELVE PARTS
by Annie Zaidi
ALEPH
₹499; 136 pages

HOW DOES ONE WRITE ABOUT AN INDIAN metropolis? The classic Mumbai novel is supposed to be as unwieldy, chaotic and verbose as the city itself; art mirrors reality. In *City of Incident*, Annie Zaidi gives us a slim quiet counter-novel that is the very opposite: A sense of macabre colours the 12 interlocking stories about as many characters, which include a beggar, a balloon seller, a snake charmer and a trinket seller, "the invisible people on the peripheries of our vision".

Zaidi tries to pierce the inner lives of "a great city's most powerless inhabitants" but, ironically, ends up erasing them physically, emotionally and literally—all the characters in this book are nameless. Writing about the Other in India carries the risk of the English-speaking author imposing her own misplaced empathy and guilt, not to mention romanticised observation, on the Other. Unlike England, the working class or the tramp does not write back here. Unlike Joseph Mitchell in *Up in the Old Hotel*—about the lost souls of New York—Zaidi doesn't seem to have had a conversation with any of these 'types'; she relies on her imagination, newspaper clippings and impersonal sightings.



ZAIDI TRIES TO PIERCE THE INNER LIVES OF "A GREAT CITY'S MOST POWERLESS INHABITANTS" BUT, IRONICALLY, ENDS UP ERASING THEM

How does she know that the salesgirl aspires to eat avocados? Maybe she hates avocados and prefers *batata vada*. Does a beggar wonder that he will not even "become a statistic"? No wonder, the best story is about the building society security guard, someone the author has perhaps known from close quarters. The same is true of the passages describing the experiences of travelling as a woman in the Mumbai local.

There is generalisation here: Is there anything like a "heavy northeastern accent"? There are odd phrases: Is uncooked chawal called "raw rice"? Poverty porn too: "A dust-covered baby, its naked bottom pressed against the man's belly" and "his matted brown hair and bony ankles". The author's affinity for fluffy lyricism is at odds with the harshness of the reality she seeks to portray: "White light bouncing of metal. Moonlight glinting on railway tracks"; "motes of dust in a shaft of light". Zaidi also has a flair for the unilluminating metaphor: "chewing her morsel of time like her mother chewed tobacco"; "trains snuffled down its length like the fat-flecked blood in her mother's arteries"; and "The words had dropped from his lips like pigeon shit on lamp posts". There are sentences of overwrought abstraction: "The city's fingers unfurl and let loose a stream of bags" and "they too have been let loose at this spot by the unseeing fingers of time".

This "novel in twelve parts" comes across as a slickly-produced album, whose songs are unable to overcome pretentious stylisation. ■

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra

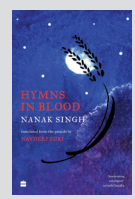
On the Same Page

Alongside the Booker-winning Tomb of Sand, *here are other new translations you should shop for*



CHRONICLES OF THE LOST DAUGHTERS
by Debarati Mukhopadhyay; translated by Arunava Sinha
HARPERCOLLINS
₹399; 336 pages

About to be sold into slavery, Bhubonomi only has reason to curse her fate, but destiny has other plans for her. Rabindranath Tagore and Wajid Ali Shah are also characters in the novel (originally *Narach* in Bengali).



HYMNS IN BLOOD
by Nanak Singh; translated by Navdeep Suri
HARPER PERENNIAL
₹499; 239 pages

First published as *Khoon de Sohile* (1948) in Punjabi, this novel tells the story of how Baba Bhana and his family are forced to leave Chakri, their village near Rawalpindi. Made perilous by communal violence, their journey is one of quiet resilience.



HUNGRY HUMANS
by Karichan Kunju; translated by Sudha G. Tilak
PENGUIN VIKING
₹599; 270 pages

Returning to his hometown after four decades, Ganesan has much to come to terms with—leprosy, his sexual identity, his disavowal of Brahmanical morality. This translation of *Pasitha Manidam* (1978) is as groundbreaking as its Tamil original.